The Giant's Tooth

By Bruce Coville

EDGAR TWONKY had no intention of getting eaten by a giant the morning he left for Cottleston Fair. Sometimes these things just happen.

He was ambling along, humming tunelessly, when an enormous hand swept down from the sky, scooped him up, and deposited him in a mouth the size of a cave.

The tongue on which he landed was coarse and soggy, like a bed of rain-soaked ferns. It flung him toward the back of the mouth, where a vast bulb of red flesh dangled above the gaping black hole that would, Edgar presumed, be the last thing he ever saw. With a leap, Edgar grabbed the dangling piece of flesh. It was moist and slick, and far too wide for him to put his arms around. Digging his fingers into the soft surface, he hung on for dear life.

"Gunnarrrgh." said the giant. *"Gunnarrrgh."*

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INTRODUCTION

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Edgar's grip was loosening, and he was expecting to fall into the waiting hole at any second, when he heard a creaky voice call, "Over here! Hurry!"

Edgar flung himself forward, landing on the giant's tongue once more. The great pad of flesh rippled alarmingly as the giant tried to swallow him.

MEAGAN: Come on, come on! I can't hold this out here forever. It'll make him sneeze, which will almost certainly kill you!

Reaching forward, Edgar grabbed another handful of tongue and pulled himself along the rough surface. He dragged himself hand over hand toward the beckoning torch, when the giant made a last desperate attempt to swallow him. *"Gak gak gak."* hacked the giant.

Edgar leaped forward, landing within a foot of the torch. A withered hand reached out to him. He

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grabbed it thankfully and was pulled into the most astonishing room he had ever seen.

Well, it wasn't a room, exactly. It was the inside of one of the giant's back teeth. But the flickering light of the torch showed that it had been hollowed out to make an area large enough to hold a table and two chairs and a clutter of items that covered both floor and table: cups, plates, knives, pitchforks, shovels, coils of rope, chunks of wood, and an old wagon wheel, among other things.

"Salvage," wheezed a voice behind him.

Edgar turned and received yet another surprise. His rescuer was a woman.

MEAGAN: By salvage, I mean the stuff in the room, not you. First time since I've been here that I've actually been able to save someone. Silly things all panic and slide down his gullet before I can do a thing to help them. That was very good, the way you managed to grab on to something. Quick thinking. I like that in a man.

EDGAR: *(nervously)* Thank you. (looking around) How

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long have you lived here?

MEAGAN: *(shrugging)* Can't really say. It's hard to keep track of the time in here. *(stroking her hair, sadly)* I do know I was young when he took me. Young and pretty, some thought. And my hair was black as a raven's wing. Now come on, ducky. Sit down, sit down. I haven't had a visitor in . . . well, ever, actually. *(flipping hair over shoulder)* My name is Meagan.

EDGAR: And I'm Edgar. How do you live here, anyway? Where do you get your food?

MEAGAN: *(shrugging)* I scavenge. Anything that comes along that doesn't go down his gullet. I've dug bits of meat out of his teeth that would feed a family of ten.

Edgar shuddered, and decided not to ask what she did for water. He was afraid he already knew the answer. He leaped ahead to the bigger, more important question. "Have you ever tried to get out?"

MEAGAN: *(bitterly)* What do I look like? Of course

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I've tried to get out. I tried every way I could think of. Finally, when it became clear I wasn't going to make it, I gave up and accepted my fate. With every flash of light that came when the giant opened his mouth, I took stock of where I was. Many was the hour I spent huddled in this tooth, weeping to myself, wondering what was to become of me. But I never gave up. I drank from pools of spit. I snatched passing food. And when I found my first tool, I began to dig, to make myself a home. Chip, chip, chip, I picked away at this tooth. *(pause, chuckles)* He didn't like that, I can tell you. Oh, the roars of pain! I thought I would go deaf. *(Beat)* Did I try to get out? Of course I tried to get out. But in the end, I made myself a home here.

Night inside the giant's tooth came in two stages. The first was when the giant himself lay down to rest, which changed the floor into a wall, and the rear wall into the floor. Stage two came when Meagan decided to put out the torch.

As he lay in the dark, wrapped in misery,

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Edward finally did drift into a fitful slumber-only to be jolted back into wakefulness by a deep rumble, something like a cross between a thunderstorm and an avalanche. *(Sound of giant snoring, ending in 3 peeps)*

EDGAR: *(horrified)* What was that?

MEAGAN: *(groggily)* What was what?

(Sound of giant snoring, ending in 3 peeps)

EDGAR: That!

MEAGAN: *(snarling)* It's just the giant, snoring. Forget it and go back to sleep.

He was still wide awake, though completely exhausted, when Meagan lit the torch again. Only a few moments later the giant groaned and lurched to his feet, causing everything that had fallen to the wall the night before to return to the floor.

MEAGAN: I've been thinking, and I've decided that you're going to have to build a home of your own. This place really is too small for the two of us. Odds are good I'd end up killing you.

Edgar, who was still determined to think of this as a temporary situation, felt that digging out

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his own home would be a waste of time and energy.

EDGAR: *(snarling whine)* Where do you suggest I make this home.

MEAGAN: *(snapping)* Well, he has nearly thirty more teeth to choose from! However, I'd suggest you stick with the molars. They're roomier.

And so, after a breakfast so gray that Edgar decided he didn't really want to know what it consisted of, they left Meagan's home to search for a tooth where he could live.

The giant's tongue, pulsating beside them like a pink and fleshy whale, was a constant danger. Even worse, when they first started out they had to dodge into the gap between Meagan's tooth and the next one while the giant poked at their hiding spot with the tip of his tongue, as if he was trying to dislodge an irritating bit of food that had become stuck there. It was a humbling thought for Edgar to realize that "an irritating bit of food" was, in fact, precisely what he had become.

The tooth directly next to Meagan's was

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strong and solid, with no obvious place for Edgar to begin excavating a home. The one next to that, however-the tooth farthest back in the giant's mouth-had a hole twice the size of Edgar's fist. The odor of decay hung rank about it, but Meagan said that would disappear when Edgar had cut away the rot.

Before Meagan would let him start to work, she bound them both to the tooth with a combination of ropes and leather straps.

Edgar swung the pick and knocked away a chunk of the yellowed enamel. The outraged roar of pain that rose from deep within the giant nearly deafened him. Edgar almost felt sorry for the giant. Then he reminded himself that the only reason the creature was suffering this way was because it had tried to eat him.

The outer coating of the tooth was hard but brittle, and broke away fairly easily. After about four feet, the material changed to something dense and yellow, and tougher to work with the pick.

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Finally the time came when the excavation in the tooth was big enough for Edgar to take up his home in it. He moved his things-that is, the two or three items Meagan had given him, as well as a pitchfork (the single thing he had managed to snag on his own)-to his new abode.

While he continued work on his new dwelling, Meagan taught him how to snatch things from the tide of food and rubble that poured down the giant's throat three times a day. When she "went fishing," as she called it, she first secured a safety rope about her waist, anchoring the other end of the rope to one of the chairs inside her tooth. Normally she pulled things in with the help of a long pole that had a hook on one end. But if something particularly good came rushing past that was too far out on the tongue for her to snag simply by leaning for it, she would fling her whole body onto the surface of the tongue, then use the rope to haul herself back.

Once Edgar was truly settled, he began to explore the giant's mouth in search of a way out.

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Though he did not tell Meagan this was what he was doing, he suspected she was able to guess. Not that it made any difference. He could find no way of escape. It was like being at the bottom of a well: easy enough to fall in, impossible to climb out.

Edgar continued his explorations, until he had at last reached the most distant of the giant's molars. He carried a torch with him, which he lit and waved to Meagan when he reached the far side.

When he returned from that trip, he was burning with a new idea.

EDGAR: If we string a rope directly across the center of his mouth, we might have better luck snagging things as they go by.

MEAGAN: Might work.

Just how good an idea became clear as the weeks rolled on and they were able to retrieve more and more items. The most unexpected of these items was a young man named Charles, whom Edgar snatched from certain doom by hanging upside down from the rope and reaching out to him.

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During Edgar's second year in the giant's mouth, they rescued Farley. Next to be pulled to safety, about six months later, were a pair of sisters, named Babette and Cleo, and their dim-witted brother, Herbert. The time had come to begin building homes in the teeth on the other side of the mouth. Babette and Cleo chose to live together. Herbert took the tooth above them.

Before too many more years had passed, a thriving community had risen in the giant's mouth. Edgar was elected mayor of Giant's Mouth Township. They gave him a jeweled scepter, which they had managed to retrieve one afternoon when the giant swallowed a king. (They had tried to save the king, too, of course, but his grip was weak and flabby, and he had not been able to hold on when Herbert reached out to him.)

Many was the night Edgar sat in his tooth and looked out the window he had carved on the tongueward side, feeling warm and cozy at the sight of the lights twinkling on the other side of the

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giant's mouth. In this way, the years rolled on.

And then, one afternoon while he was setting a rope, Edgar was suddenly yanked from the giant's mouth. It happened because the giant, who was in a foul mood that day, became particularly irritated by the feeling of things moving in his mouth. Edgar was stringing a rope across the roof of the giant's mouth in order to do some salvage work when the giant reached in and began to scratch at the roof of his mouth. Though the rope was less to him than a silk thread would be to a human, it caught on his fingernail. When he pulled his hand out, one end of the rope came free-and with it, still clinging to the end, came Edgar.

As he hurtled out of the giant's mouth, two things caused Edgar to blink. The first was the unexpected brightness of the sun, which he had not seen except at a distance for so many years. The second was the horrifying distance that separated him from the ground.

Knowing he could not keep his grip on the

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saliva-slick rope, Edgar made a desperate leap and landed on the giant's collar. The giant swatted at him, as one would at an annoying insect, but Edgar quickly scrambled under the giant's collar, where he held as still as he could, scarcely breathing.

Finally night darkened the sky, bringing with it the stars that he had not seen in so many years. Their beauty made him weep. The giant lay down, and after a time began to snore. Edgar climbed out onto his chest. He stood, staring out at the rising moon, the river on whose water it was reflected, the dark ridge of the distant mountains, and the road that led back to his village.

Then he began to climb the giant's shirt-not down, but up-onto the giant's chin, where the stubble grew so thick it was like a grove of small pine trees. Across the loose and pendulous lip Edgar climbed. Then he lowered himself back into the moist cavern of the giant's mouth, where his home and friends lay waiting.

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